Question: Choose **one** sharing or gig economy platform (for example, Uber, Airbnb, or TaskRabbit) and, drawing on Howcroft and Bergvall-Kåreborn's (2019) typology of crowdwork, construct an argument about how a specific feature of the platform's design shapes who benefits and who is exploited by its model of work.

Safety by Design? Benefits and Hidden Costs of DiDi's Female-Driver Priority

Introduction

In the gig economy, lean platforms coordinate services through software while outsourcing labour and operating costs through a "hyper-outsourced model" (Srnicek, 2017, p. 43). DiDi, also known as DiDi Chuxing, is a Chinese gig economy platform that connects passengers with drivers through an app. One of its features is an optional female-driver priority preference. Drawing on Howcroft and Bergvall-Kåreborn's (2019) typology of crowdwork, this essay argues that this feature can address female passengers' safety concerns and give women drivers additional orders and supportive interactions by prioritising matches between them, but that exploitation risks arise when longer pickups and gendered service expectations cause additional costs. This essay will first examine how the preference operates within DiDi's matching rules, then consider its benefits for female passengers and drivers before analysing the potential costs and additional service demands placed on women drivers.

From Preference to Matching Rule

As a Type C gig platform, besides connecting passengers with available drivers, DiDi

uses its optional female-driver priority feature to transform female passengers' gender preference into a work-allocation rule. According to Howcroft and Bergvall-Kåreborn (2019), Type C crowdwork is defined as paid, asset-based services that are digitally managed but performed offline through workers' assets, such as cars (pp. 27-28). Applied to DiDi, it fits this model since drivers use their vehicles to provide driving services, while the platform controls the interface and matching system through various designed features. For the optional female-driver preference setting, passengers can access it from DiDi's booking screen, as Figure 1(a) shows. In more detail, the settings in Figure 1(b) allow eligible female customers to prioritise women drivers all day, at night only, for the current trip, or to leave the preference disabled. Once enabled, the feature prioritises women drivers during the first thirty seconds of matching, then expands the request to all drivers to avoid a long wait if too few female drivers are available nearby. These settings let female passengers decide when to request priority, while DiDi still determines how long that priority lasts, since a passenger willing to wait longer for a woman driver cannot extend the thirty seconds through these settings. In this sense, although female passengers' preferences become actionable choices, they remain limited by DiDi's matching rules and the availability of women drivers.

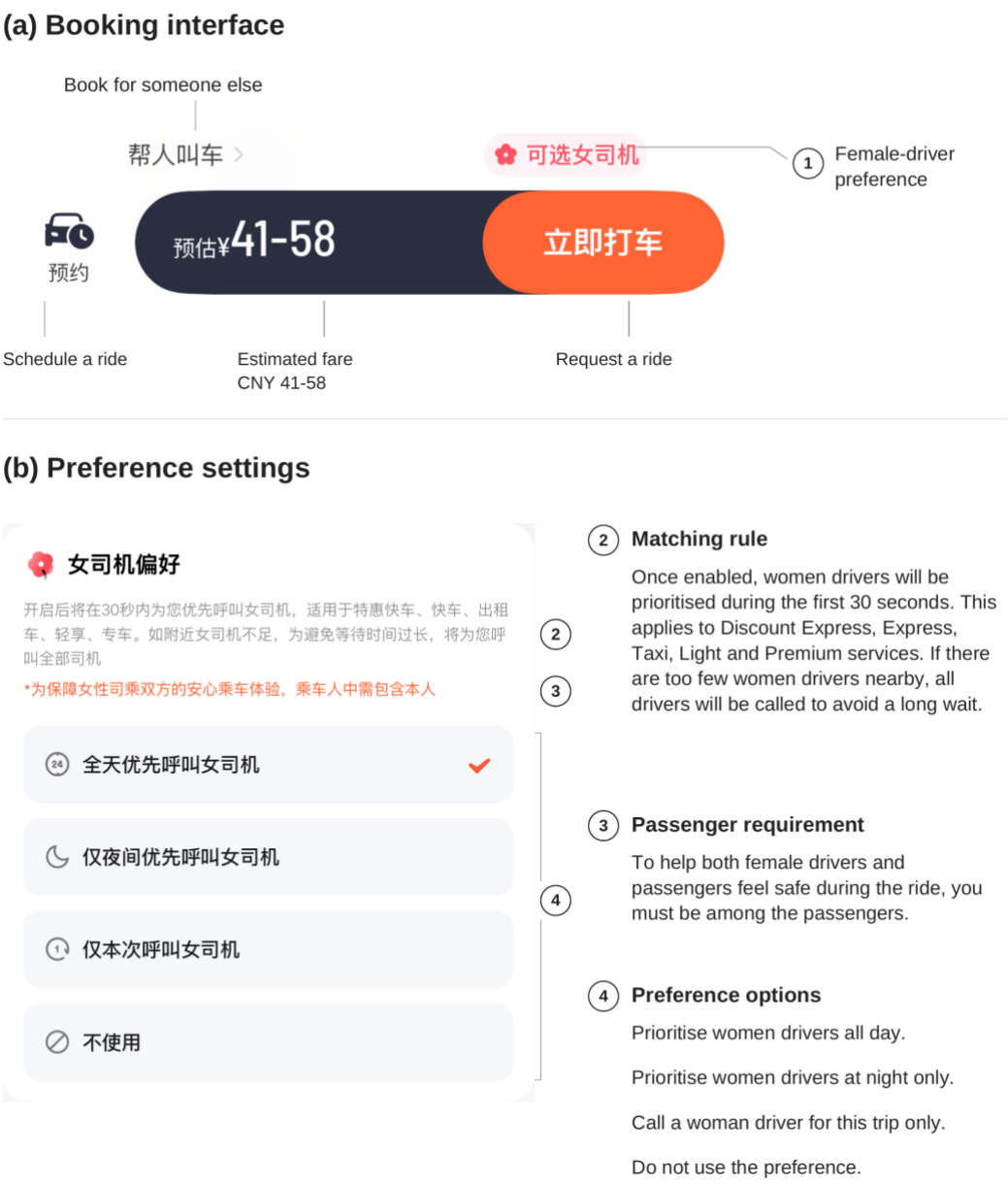


Figure 1. DiDi's Female Driver Preference and Matching Conditions

Note. (a) Entry point on DiDi's booking interface. (b) Preference settings, including the matching rule, passenger requirements, and available options. Screenshots from the DiDi mobile app captured on September 15, 2026, cropped, arranged, and translated by the author.

Benefits for Female Passengers and Drivers

When it comes to the benefits, the feature may help female passengers address safety concerns about travelling alone, particularly at night. Hu and Yang (2024) find that female passengers adopt precautions such as avoiding solo nighttime journeys and suggest that their safety concerns can be eased by matching them with women drivers (pp. 14-15). DiDi's night-only setting aligns with this suggestion, which allows female passengers to apply this preference during nighttime journeys, giving them optional control over who they travel with when they feel vulnerable.

From the perspective of benefited female drivers, additional bookings and supportive interactions with female passengers improve their working experience. An article published on the Chinese social media platform Sohu, featuring interviews with several women drivers in Beijing, reports that DiDi's female-driver priority brought Yanzi, one of the interviewed women drivers, additional transactions, while female passengers made her feel cared for by encouraging her to finish work early in the rain and offering voluntary monetary gifts and tips (Boke COVER, 2026). Through these interactions, women drivers can gain more earning opportunities and supportive treatment from passengers who actively seek their services. However, this does not guarantee a higher net income, especially since additional orders bring new costs.

The Costs Behind Priority Matching

One of the limitations for women drivers that priority matching can create is the higher cost when they fulfil longer pickups. Since Type C work is "time and place-dependent and so carries obvious geographical limitations" (Howcroft & Bergvall-

Kåreborn, 2019, p. 28), matching a passenger with a woman driver remains dependent on where drivers are available and how far they must travel in DiDi. As Figure 2 shows, one commenter relays a woman driver's account of pickups over three kilometers away and reduced earnings, with a callout for better platform protection under a post that appreciates DiDi's female-driver priority feature on Xiaohongshu. This reported experience reveals that some women drivers who gain priority in work allocation may be required to bear additional time and fuel costs. If uncompensated, these long pickup costs could offset the earnings for women drivers.

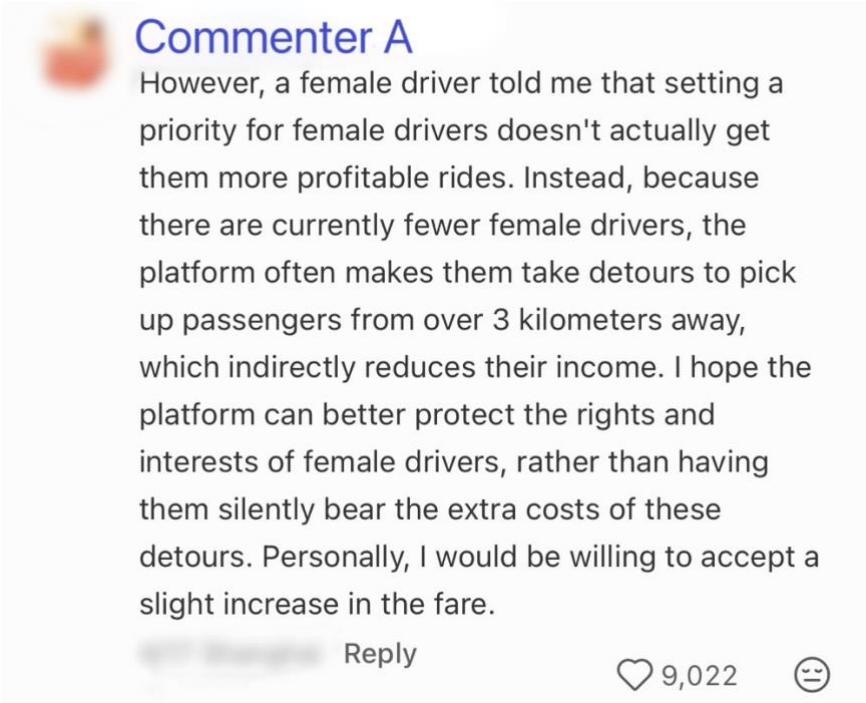


Figure 2. Xiaohongshu Comment Reporting a Woman Driver's Experience of Longer Pickups

Note. Usernames and avatars have been anonymised. The Chinese comment has been automatically translated into English by Xiaohongshu. Screenshot captured and edited by the author on September 15, 2026.

Besides the increasing pickup cost, emotional and material demands on women drivers may also arise through using female-driver priority when passengers expect their choice of a woman driver to include extra care and comfort. For one thing, because “emotional labour has long been a key element of interactive service work”, “workers are judged on their activities by customers” and “negative reviews serve as disciplinary instruments” in Type C services (Howcroft & Bergvall-Kåreborn, 2019, p. 28), passengers’ expectations can become pressure for drivers to manage feelings and behaviour to avoid disappointing customers. Research on Chinese DiDi drivers identifies expectations that women “perform more emotional labour” and “present themselves as a loving mother” (Kwan, 2025, p. 343). These expectations construct listening, comforting and remaining patient as obligations attached to being a woman driver. Kwan also reports Wei’s tiredness from advising and comforting passengers, alongside her concern about damaging her ratings in DiDi as an example (2025, p. 343). Another related expectation criticised by the commenter is that choosing a female driver equals receiving a fragrant or exceptionally clean car, as Figure 3 shows. Taken together, these expectations involve material costs, while managing feelings to remain patient and caring carries emotional labour. The risk of exploitation arises since gendered expectations become service demands that women drivers feel pressured to meet.

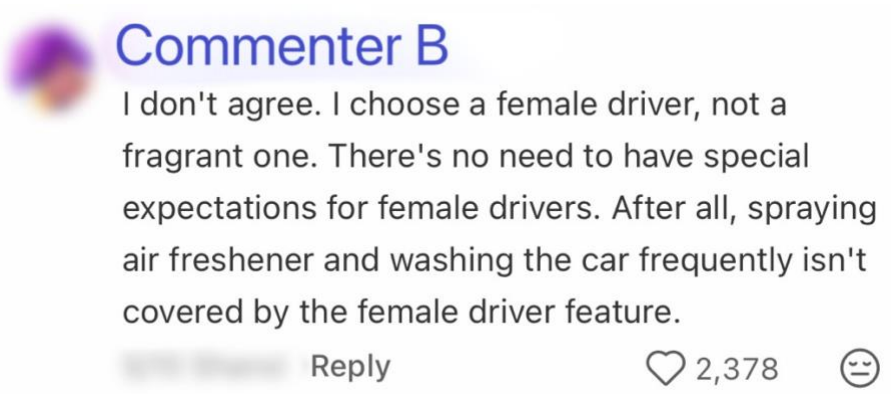


Figure 3. Xiaohongshu Comment Challenging Additional Service Expectations for Women Drivers

Note. Usernames and avatars have been anonymised. The Chinese comment has been automatically translated into English by Xiaohongshu. Screenshot captured and edited by the author on September 15, 2026.

Conclusion

In conclusion, bringing a gender perspective to the Type C framework, this essay highlights how DiDi's female-driver priority can support women as both passengers and workers while exposing women drivers to additional costs shaped by gendered service expectations. For future research, it is suggested to examine how DiDi responds to these concerns, particularly whether its matching, compensation, and customer-rating policies reduce or reinforce female drivers' extra burdens.

(1023 words)

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